(Not a) Map of (not the) Territory

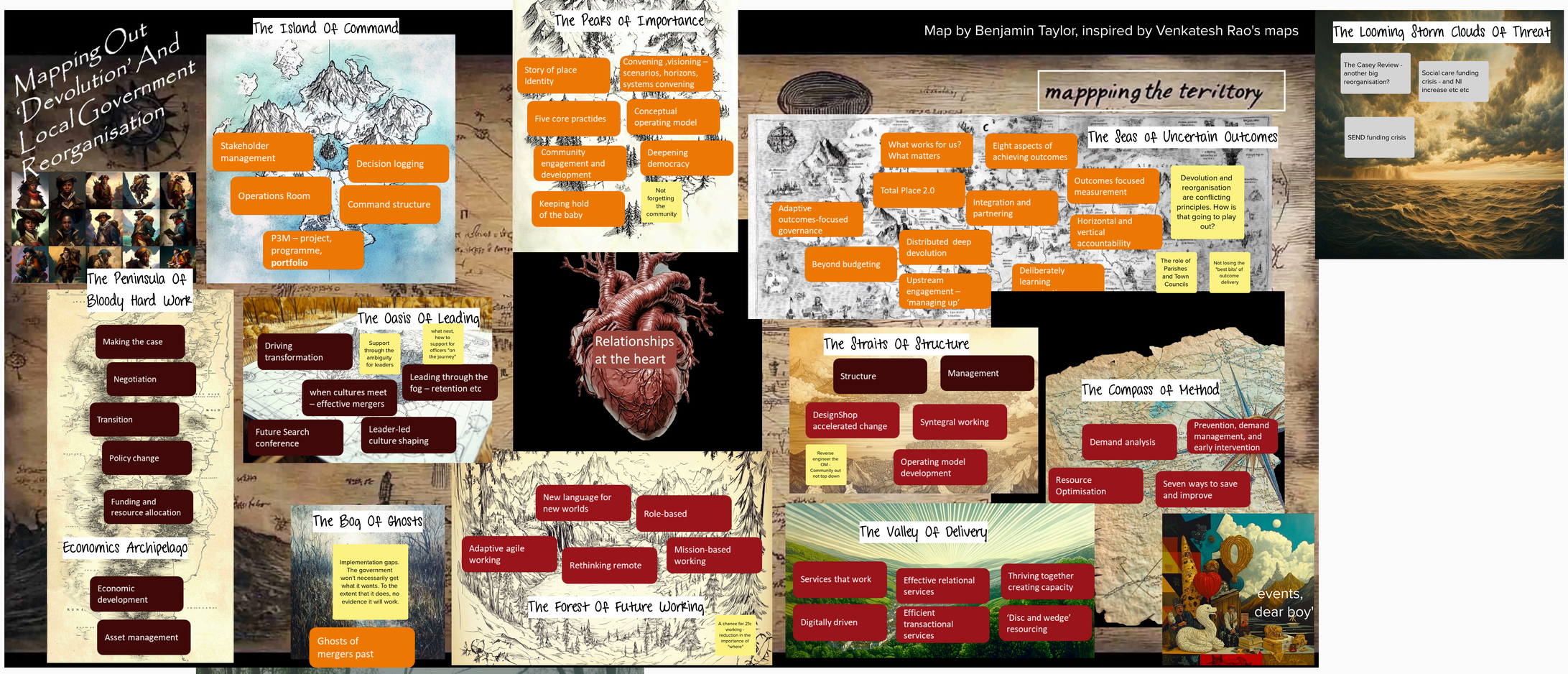












You can't take everyone on the bus. If this is a real change, 30-70% of senior managers will move on. The only choice is whether you acknowledge that reality and manage it well—or let it happen chaotically.

At each others' throats. The senior relationships are absolutely critical – in a City Council where the chief executive and chair of CCG hated each other, a major devolution opportunity was lost.

Mayoral stramash. Mayoral systems can lead to even bigger swings than party politics – and in some cases, have led independent officers to develop loyalty which contributed to nasty politics and failure.

In it for their own reasons. Different drivers of different organizations or parts of organizations can stymie collaboration.

The Borg imperative. The more local government is standardised as a delivery body for the centre, the more its value disappears. Once there's "no additionality," full centralisation is the inevitable next step.

The battle of the assets and the debts. A district council set up an uncontrolled free-standing body to 'support community and business development' in their area to keep funds out of the hands of the county council. The other side of this is the battle to avoid taking on large debts.

Royalty succeeds by acclaim, not competition. The story of a successful Strategic Alliance (and several unsuccessful ones) shows that reducing the number of Chief Executives and senior leadership works when there's no competition, and when you start from senior leadership on down.

The symbolism of the email address. Three councils tried a deep merger but never managed to create a single unified email domain. That failure spoke volumes. If you can't get the small things right, the big things will fail too.

Grass-roots and astroturf find a way. The importance of local politics cannot be overstated – however much you try to run politics top-down, you open up the possibility of bottom up (or outside influence)

The reverse ferret. A failed district bid for unitarisation was reversed when district politicians won the next election and reshaped the county unitary along their own lines. Political realities will always reassert themselves.

Remember who you were. Those who held on to wider geographic area services and connections (social care, libraries, planning, and smaller services etc.) did much better over the years.

Your homework is marked by the powerful departments.

Working with a county on a Commissioning Academy based around their Sustainable Transformation Plan and the NHS couldn't proceed because of the Secretary of State.

One City chief exec went up against DoH as STP lead – and lost, badly.
In considering a sensitive and expensive national system, DHSC fought with DfE – and MHCLG weren't in the battle.

In original negotiations for Public Service Boards (shaping "all" local spending), ODPM was not able to get in the game compared to Treasury, DWP, DoH and DfE.

You have to make your arguments to all these departments, separately.